Founder Access Continuity Organizer

If you are unreachable tomorrow, someone you trust can keep the business alive — without you ever writing a password in this kit.

1. How to use this kit (read this first)

Read this guide once, then work the companion workbook sheet by sheet. The workbook is the record; this guide is the method. Nothing here asks you to make a decision you cannot undo, and nothing here asks you to trust a stranger: every step is something you do yourself, today, while you are calm, so that someone else does not have to improvise later while they are not. A one-person business has no second pair of hands by design — which is exactly why the knowledge of how it runs has to live somewhere other than your head. The work is small: about ninety minutes to fill the inventory the first time, half an hour to set up emergency access, and thirty minutes a year to keep it true. What it buys is the difference between a business that pauses if you are gone and a business that ends.

- **This guide:** the method, the rule that makes it safe, the three-envelope system, and the successor's first 72 hours.
- **The workbook:** the inventory (Systems, Holders, Envelopes, DrillLog) and a Dashboard that computes your coverage and flags the gaps.
- **Where to start:** fill Systems and Holders first. Those two sheets are the whole point; everything else protects them.

2. The one rule that makes this safe: an inventory, never a vault

The most dangerous version of this kit is the one where you write your passwords down. A printed password list in a drawer, a spreadsheet called passwords.xlsx, a note in your phone — each of them converts a business problem into a security breach, and the breach is the more likely of the two events. So this kit is built on a single rule: **it records what exists, where it lives, and who may touch it — never the secret itself.** Where you would be tempted to write a password, write the recovery route instead: how a legitimate owner restores access (an email reset to a shared inbox, a branch visit with identity documents, a support ticket from a recovery address). The recovery route is what your successor actually needs, and it is not a liability if it is ever exposed.

The secrets themselves belong in a real password manager with an emergency-access feature — most major managers include one, and this kit is deliberately provider-agnostic so you can use whichever you already trust. The manager holds your vault; the manager's emergency-access setting decides who can reach it, and after how long; and this kit records only the name of the manager and the name of the person you granted access to. That split is the whole design: one place holds the secrets and is defended by the manager's own cryptography, and one place holds the map and can be read by anyone without harm.

3. What “unreachable” actually means for a one-person business

It is a mistake to plan only for the worst case. A founder can be effectively gone for a week to the business while still very much alive: a hospital stay with no laptop, a family emergency, a long flight to a place with no signal, a bad flu that removes you for ten days. In each of those, the business still has

clients waiting for replies, invoices that need sending, subscriptions that auto-renew, and a bank that will not talk to anyone but you. The plan you are building is not a death plan. It is a plan for any period during which you cannot be reached, and the same plan happens to cover the terminal case for free.

That reframing matters because it changes what you have to protect. The goal is not to hand over the whole business; it is to make sure the business does not quietly break while you are away. That is a much smaller job: keep the lights on for thirty days, keep clients informed, keep money moving, and leave the big decisions for you to make when you are back. The workbook calls this the keep-alive plan, and thirty days is a deliberate choice — long enough to cover a serious event, short enough that nobody has to make irreversible calls on your behalf.

4. The three-envelope method

The method names three things that must exist, who holds each, and how each is opened. The envelopes are a way of thinking, not literal stationery, though a physical envelope is a fine way to store the third one.

- **Envelope A — the map.** This inventory. It lists what exists, where it lives, and who may touch it. It contains no secrets, so it can be printed, stored with the workbook, and read by your successor without risk. Anyone who finds it learns how the business is organised, not how to break into it.
- **Envelope B — the keys.** Password-manager emergency access. You grant one trusted person access today, and the manager enforces a waiting period before it unlocks, so an unauthorised request gives you time to notice and cancel it. This kit records only the manager's name and the holder's name.
- **Envelope C — the letter.** A sealed document held by a lawyer or kept in a safe. It contains a master-password *hint* (never the password), the lawyer's and accountant's contacts, and the thirty-day keep-alive steps in your own words. It is opened only by the named successor or on a stated condition you choose.

The reason for three and not one is that each fails differently. A single document that holds everything is one theft or one lost drawer away from disaster. Three, separated by who holds them and what they contain, mean that the loss of any one of them degrades your plan instead of destroying it.

5. Step one — inventory what exists

Open the Systems sheet and walk through your business as if you were a stranger trying to run it. For each thing the business needs, record what it is, where it lives, which account owns it, and — importantly — the route by which a legitimate owner restores access. Do not stop at the obvious. The list that matters is the one that includes the unglamorous items nobody thinks of as critical until they are gone: the domain registrar (lose it and your website and email stop), the business bank (the only place money can move), the payment processor (where revenue actually lands), the email account that is the recovery address for everything else, and the file storage that holds the work itself.

Assign each a criticality from one to five. A five means the business stops within days if it is lost; a one means it is a convenience. Be honest rather than generous — a list where everything is a five cannot be prioritised, and the value of this sheet is the ranking. Then fill the recovery route for each one while you still remember it. This is the step people skip, and it is the step that makes the difference between a successor who is stuck and a successor who is moving.

6. Step two — the two-person rule and the criticality test

For every system rated four or higher, ask a single hard question: could a second trusted person restore access to this without me? If the answer is no — if the only route runs through your memory, your phone, or your personal email — mark the two-person rule as N, and treat that as a real gap rather than a technicality. The Dashboard adds up the critical systems with no second person and shows the count at the top. Most founders who do this exercise honestly discover between three and six such systems the first time, and those are the ones that decide whether the business survives a bad week.

- A shared login is not a second person. If two people use one account, neither can prove who did what, and revoking one revokes both. Create a named account for the second person instead.
- The recovery email is the weakest link in most setups. If every account resets through one inbox that only you can open, then every system you rate as critical is really only protected by that one inbox.
- Fix the highest criticality gap first. Do not try to make everything perfect on day one; close the five that would end the business, then stop.

7. Step three — name who may act

Open the Holders sheet. Name the people who may act on the business, what each may touch, and the basis on which they may do it. Keep it short: a successor or executor, a backup operator who can reach the systems, and the professionals who already know the business — your accountant and your lawyer. For each, record how they are reached, which categories they may touch, and whether you have actually confirmed the arrangement with them. A holder you have never spoken to is not a holder; they are a name on a list.

Be clear with yourself about the boundary here. Authority that carries legal weight — a power of attorney, an executor's role, a will — is not something this kit can grant or replace; it has to be drawn up properly by a lawyer where you live, and it has to match the reality of how your business is registered. What this sheet does is the part the law does not do for you: it records who you have told, what you have told them, and that you have confirmed they are willing. Get the legal instruments drawn up separately, and use this sheet to make sure the people named in them can actually find the map.

8. Step four — set up password-manager emergency access, today

This is the one step worth doing immediately, because it is the step that takes your plan from a document to a working system. The mechanics are the same in broad outline whichever manager you use, and none of them require you to share a password with anyone.

■ Install or open your password manager and make sure your vault is actually complete — an emergency grant to an empty vault helps nobody.

■ Find the emergency-access or account-recovery setting; most major managers offer one, sometimes under a name like emergency contact or trusted contact.

■ Grant access to exactly one trusted person, and choose a waiting period long enough that you would notice an unexpected request and could cancel it.

■ Note in the Envelopes sheet the manager's name and the holder's name — and nothing else. Never write the master password or the hint here.

■ Walk the flow once, on purpose, so you know what your successor will see. Then close it again.

■ Tell the person you granted access that they have it, and what you want them to do if the waiting period ever completes.

9. Step five — the thirty-day keep-alive plan

The keep-alive plan is what your successor does first, and it is deliberately small. Write it in your own words on the last page of this kit and in Envelope C, and keep it to things that must happen for the business not to break: answer or acknowledge the clients with live work, keep the essential subscriptions from lapsing, make sure any payroll or contractor payments still go out, and pause any spending that only makes sense while you are working — new campaigns, new purchases, new commitments. Thirty days of keeping the machine idling is a realistic ask of someone who is not you. Thirty days of running the business is not, and planning for it would be a way of avoiding the simpler plan that actually works.

Name, in the same place, the decisions your successor must *not* make: do not sign new contracts, do not sell or transfer the business, do not cancel anything you might want back, do not close accounts. Your absence should not become the moment the business changes shape. The keep-alive plan exists precisely so that the only thing that has to be decided in your absence is the decision to wait for you.

10. Step six — the annual thirty-minute drill

An untested plan is a wish. Once a year, set thirty minutes aside and run the DrilLog. Do not merely read the sheets — test them. Confirm that the emergency contact is still the right person and still reachable, that the password-manager emergency flow still exists and still works the way you expect, that the inventory still matches reality (new tools and closed accounts are the usual drift), that the location of Envelope C is still known to its holder, and that the accountant and lawyer are still the current ones. Record what broke, fix it, and let the workbook compute the next due date so the calendar nags you instead of your memory.

The drill is not busywork. Almost every plan that fails in reality failed at a detail the owner could have caught in thirty minutes: a recovery email that was a dead address, a phone number that changed, a manager whose free tier had dropped the emergency feature. The drill is how you find those while they are still cheap.

11. Your successor's first 72 hours

Give your successor this sequence, in this order, so they are not improvising. Open Envelope A and read the map. Contact the named holders and tell them the situation, starting with the backup operator and the accountant. Open Envelope B through the password manager's own emergency flow — this is why you tested it. Send the client acknowledgement from the keep-alive plan, so nobody with live work is left wondering. Then do only what the keep-alive plan lists, and stop: the plan is written for thirty days of stability, and everything beyond it waits for you. The whole point of the work you did today is that this sequence is boring, and boring is what you want in the hands of someone who is worried.

12. The ten failure modes this prevents

- **The single point of failure:** one inbox, one phone, or one memory that every recovery route runs through. Prevented by the two-person rule.
- **The dead recovery address:** every reset goes to an inbox nobody else can open. Prevented by the Systems recovery column and the annual drill.
- **The written password:** a list that turns a business problem into a security breach. Prevented by the inventory-only rule.
- **The untested emergency grant:** access that was set up years ago and no longer works. Prevented by walking the flow once a year.
- **The unknowable domain:** a registrar only you can reach, expiring quietly. Prevented by naming it as a critical system.
- **The silent renewal:** subscriptions billing a card nobody else can see. Prevented by the keep-alive plan.
- **The unnamed successor:** people willing to help who never agreed to, or were never told they were named. Prevented by the Holders confirmation column.
- **The improvised decision:** a frightened substitute selling or cancelling what should have waited. Prevented by writing down what not to decide.
- **The stale plan:** a document that described the business two years ago. Prevented by the annual drill and its gaps column.
- **The plan nobody can find:** a perfect document in a drawer no one knows about. Prevented by telling the holders where Envelope C lives.

13. Boundaries — what this kit is not

This kit is an organising system. It is not a will, it does not create a power of attorney, and it does not replace legal, financial, tax or insurance advice. It records what you have arranged; it does not arrange it. Any instrument that has legal effect where you live must be prepared by a qualified professional in your jurisdiction. Password storage must follow the security rules of the manager you use, and you should never write a master password, a hint that amounts to one, or a full account number into these pages. Treat the completed workbook as sensitive for a different reason than a password list: not because it contains secrets, but because it contains the map to everything that matters.

14. FAQ

- **How long does this take the first time?** About ninety minutes for the inventory and half an hour for emergency access. The annual upkeep is thirty minutes.
- **What if I have no one to name?** Name a professional instead — your accountant or lawyer — at least as a starting point, and revisit it. A plan with one imperfect holder beats no plan.
- **Do I need a lawyer for this?** Not for the inventory. Yes for anything with legal effect, such as a will or a power of attorney. The two are complementary, not alternatives.
- **Is the workbook safe to keep on my computer?** It contains no secrets, so treating it as a map is fine; still, keep it somewhere you would keep business records, and never add a password to it.

- **What if my business is really just me and a laptop?** Then you have fewer systems but the same single point of failure, and the plan matters more, not less, because there is no colleague to cover for you.
- **Can I use a different password manager?** Yes. This kit is deliberately provider-agnostic. Use the one you trust, and record only its name and the person you granted access to.

15. Fill-in tables (print or type)

These are the same fields as the workbook's Systems and Holders sheets, for anyone who prefers to work on paper. Fill them in pen, then transfer the critical rows into the workbook so the Dashboard can compute your gaps.

Domain registrar (provider, account owner, recovery route)
Hosting / deployments (provider, who can redeploy, recovery route)
Money in and out (bank, payment processor, payout schedule)
Email account that is the recovery address for everything else
File storage holding the actual work
Password manager (product name, holder, waiting period)
Holders (name, contact, what they may touch, confirmed)
Thirty-day keep-alive steps, in your own words

16. One-page completion checklist

- ■ Every system rated 4 or 5 has a named second person who can restore access
- ■ Every critical system has a written recovery route, not a password
- ■ No password, hint or full account number appears anywhere in this kit

■ Password-manager emergency access granted to exactly one trusted person, and tested

■ Holders sheet names a successor, a backup operator, and the current professionals

■ Envelope C prepared, sealed, and its location known to its holder

■ Thirty-day keep-alive plan written in your own words, including what not to decide

■ First drill scheduled, and the DrillLog's next-due date left to compute itself

ORGANISING SYSTEM ONLY — NOT LEGAL, FINANCIAL, TAX OR INSURANCE ADVICE. This kit is not a will and does not create a power of attorney. Any instrument with legal effect where you live must be prepared by a qualified professional in your jurisdiction. Never record a password, master-password hint or full account number in this kit or its workbook.